

1993

Wind-up radio

British inventor Trevor Baylis invented the wind-up radio, the first radio that could run without batteries. This helped people who didn't have access to electricity or batteries to use a radio. When fully wound up, an internal spring stored enough energy to run the radio for about 20 minutes.



BayGen Freeplay wind-up radio, 1995



In 1994, a team led by American medical researcher Jeffrey Friedman discovered leptin, a hormone (regulatory chemical) that helps control appetite.

The handle winds up a spring, whose energy is then converted into electric power.

1993

First smartphone

IBM Simon was released as the first phone with "smart" functions: applications, email access, and a touchscreen. The 7.87-in- (20-cm-) tall phone weighed 18 oz (510 g) and could be plugged into a regular phone landline. It featured applications for accessing news, seeing maps, and sketching.



A connected world
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Single-color LCD display with touch input

Stylus used to navigate the touchscreen

Firm, fresh Flavr Savr tomatoes



1994

First genetically modified food

The Flavr Savr tomato was the first genetically modified (GM) food to go on sale to the public. These tomatoes were modified to slow their ripening process, which delayed softening and rotting.

1995



1993

First webcam

In 1991, researchers at the University of Cambridge, UK, rigged up an early digital camera to take photos of the coffee pot outside their computer laboratory, and to display the images on computers connected to their local computer network. In 1993, when web browsers had become capable of displaying images, the camera was connected to the WWW—becoming the first webcam—and remained on the Web until 2001.

Early days

Berners-Lee placed the first web server online on December 25, 1990 at CERN, Switzerland. It presented website pages to users who requested them via a web browser program running on their computers. Berners-Lee also developed HTML, a language to encode, or mark up, webpages so that they could be displayed by different computers.



1994

Comet crash

The comet Shoemaker-Levy 9 was discovered in 1993, and the following year, it crashed into Jupiter's atmosphere in the first observed collision between solar system bodies. As it broke apart, some of its fragments reached speeds of 134,216 mph (216,000 km/h). Scientists were able to learn more about comets and Jupiter's atmosphere.

Rediscovered species

The Gilbert's potoroo, thought to be extinct, was rediscovered in southwestern Australia, in 1994. The marsupial's population in the wild numbers under 100 creatures.

